A CLIENT & CLINICIAN WORKBOOK

Welcoming All of Me

Understanding and healing the parts of us shaped by trauma

A psychoeducation workbook on structural dissociation, parts, blending and unblending, self-compassion, and repairing attachment from the inside. For clients to read at their own pace, and for therapists to teach from.

Jessica Prosser, LPC | Anchored Inside

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors: Overcoming Internal Self-Alienation (Routledge, 2017). An independent summary in original wording; not affiliated with or endorsed by the author or publisher.



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01

SECTION 1

Before You Begin

This guide explains a gentle, hopeful way of understanding what trauma does inside us, and how we can heal by building a kinder relationship with every part of ourselves.

Many people who have lived through trauma, neglect or frightening relationships describe feeling divided. One day they are capable, organized and caring. The next they feel small, ashamed, furious or numb, and they can't explain why. They may want closeness and push it away at the same time. They may make plans for the future while another part of them wishes it could all end.

These experiences are confusing and often bring shame. This guide offers another explanation. Drawing on Janina Fisher's work, it describes these shifts as the activity of different **parts** of the self. Each part formed to help you get through something that was too much. Nothing is wrong with you. Your mind did what minds do when they must survive.

The book's central idea is that healing depends less on remembering every detail of what happened and more on how we relate to the parts of us who lived through it. When we stop rejecting those parts and begin to welcome them, our inner world starts to feel safer.

KEY IDEA

How to use this guide

- Read one section at a time. There is no rush, and you don't need to finish it in order.
- Notice your reactions as you read. Interest, irritation, sadness or a wish to skip ahead are all welcome. They may be parts responding.
- Try the short exercises only when you feel steady enough. Stop if you feel flooded, and return to the grounding practice in Section 14.
- Bring questions, reactions and journal notes to your therapy sessions. This approach works best with support.

SAFETY

A note on safety

This guide is educational. It does not replace therapy or a crisis plan. If you have thoughts of ending your life or harming yourself, contact your therapist, call or text **988** (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline in the U.S.), or go to your nearest emergency room.

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SECTION 2

Why We Have Parts

Dividing is not a flaw. It is one of the brain's most creative ways of surviving.

When danger is overwhelming and there's no way to escape, the mind can't afford to take in the full experience at once. One answer is **compartmentalization**. One part of the self keeps going, goes to school, smiles and does chores. Other parts carry the fear, pain and readiness to defend. This lets a child keep a sense of a "good me" and keep functioning, while the unbearable experiences are held elsewhere as "not me."

Fisher builds on the **Structural Dissociation** model of Onno van der Hart, Ellert Nijenhuis and Kathy Steele. In this model, the personality divides along natural "fault lines" in the brain and in our built-in drives. A child in an unsafe home needs both kinds of drives:

- **Daily-life drives:** to explore, learn, play, make friends, care for others and get through the day.
- **Survival drives:** the animal defenses of fight, flight, freeze, submission and crying out for help.

School might call for the curious, learning self. At home, the same child might need to stay on guard, go quiet, please an adult, or get out of the way. Switching quickly between states kept the child as safe as possible. Fisher describes this as learning that it is safer to adapt with a *system of selves* than as one fully integrated self.

Attachment adds another layer. When the person who is supposed to protect a child is also the source of fear, the child is caught between two powerful instincts: to move toward the caregiver for comfort and to move away for protection. Holding both in one small body is nearly impossible, so the mind often divides them between parts.

KEY IDEA

A key reframe

In this model, parts are not mainly storage boxes for memories. They are **ways of surviving**. Each part did a job that helped you make it to today. As Fisher often tells clients, in paraphrase: if each part had not done its job well, you would not be here now.

The difficulty is that parts stay ready for danger long after it has passed. They react to today's reminders as if the past were still happening.

REFLECTION

What did you have to do as a child to stay safe, feel loved or avoid trouble?

Which of those strategies do you still notice in yourself today?

What changes when you think of those strategies as clever survival rather than personal failings?

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

03

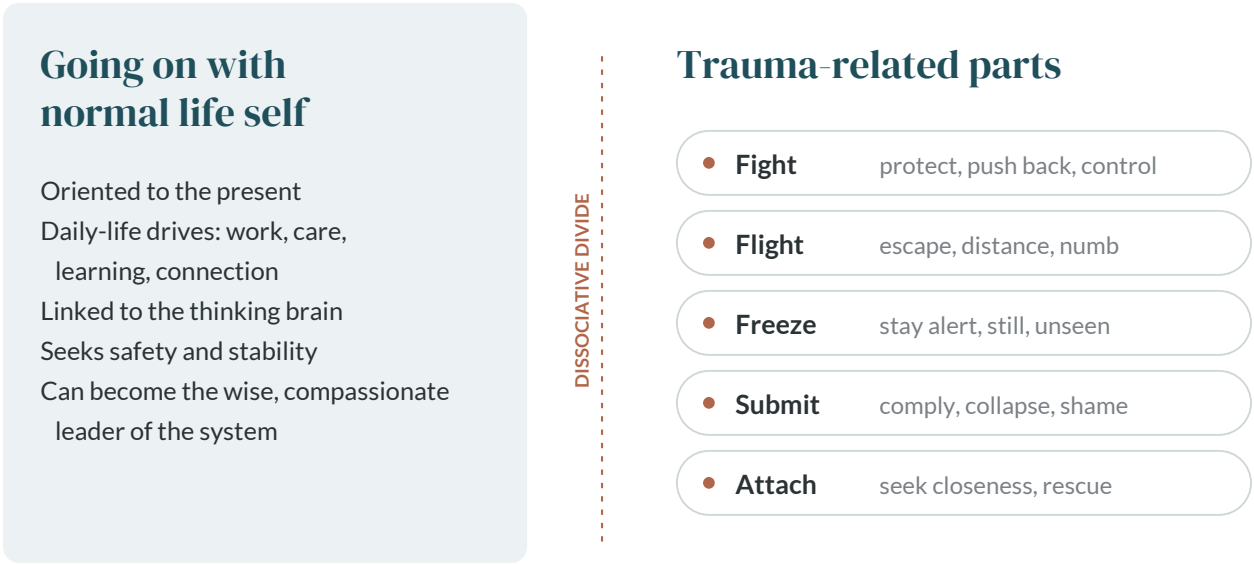
SECTION 3

The Two Sides of the Personality

One side keeps life moving forward. The other side is still braced for what happened back then.

Fisher uses plain names for the two sides described in Structural Dissociation theory.

FIGURE 1 ONE PERSONALITY, TWO SIDES



Simplified from the Structural Dissociation model (Van der Hart, Nijenhuis & Steele) as described by Fisher (2017).

KEY IDEA

The going-on-with-normal-life self

This is the part of you that gets up, goes to work, pays the bills, cares for children or pets, and keeps "putting one foot in front of the other." It is oriented to the present, linked to the thinking brain (the prefrontal cortex), and driven to seek safety, stability and an ordinary life.

- It may be tired, discouraged or overwhelmed, but it is still there.

KEY IDEA (CONT.)

- It often tries to ignore or push away the trauma-related parts so it can keep functioning.
- Many survivors dismiss it as fake, a "false self" or pretending. Fisher challenges this. It takes real courage and determination to keep going while other parts are in turmoil. A "fake" self wouldn't have to work that hard.

KEY IDEA

The trauma-related parts

These parts were shaped by danger and are driven by animal survival defenses. They are linked mostly to the emotional, nonverbal right brain and to the body's alarm system. They hold implicit memories: feelings, body sensations and impulses that weren't stored as a clear story.

- They often feel young, because they formed when you were young.
- They experience reminders as present danger, as if the past were happening now.
- They may feel like "not me," or they may feel more "real" than the functioning self.

Both sides are equally real and equally necessary. Problems come when they are cut off from each other. The functioning self may feel invaded by sudden emotions, and the young parts may feel abandoned by an adult who keeps ignoring them. Fisher notes that this inner relationship often mirrors the original traumatic environment: the vulnerable are neglected and the frightening is avoided.

TRY THIS

Try this

Think of a recent day when you got something done even though you felt bad. Name the part of you that did it. What qualities did it show, such as persistence, care, humor or organization? Write them down. This is your going-on-with-normal-life self.

NOTES

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SECTION 4

Meet the Survival Parts

Each survival part has a job, a typical way of showing itself, and something it still needs.

In Fisher's approach, clients learn to recognize parts by linking common struggles to the animal defense that drives them. The descriptions below are typical patterns, not rigid categories. Your parts may look different, and one part can blend several of these qualities.

Fight part

Protects by pushing back, watching for threat, and keeping control.

How it may show up

- Anger, irritability, mistrust, hypervigilance
- Harsh judgment of self or others, often heard as the inner critic
- Pushing people away when closeness feels risky
- In more extreme forms: self-harm, suicidal thoughts, aggression

Its gift: Strength, protection, and refusing to be hurt again

What it may still need: Respect for its strength, clear boundaries, fairness, a sense of control over threat

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

Flight part

Protects by getting distance from people, feelings or commitment.

How it may show up

- Restlessness, the urge to leave, ambivalence about relationships
- Avoiding closeness, "one foot out the door"
- Numbing or escaping through substances, food or busyness
- Spacing out to get away from unbearable feelings

Its gift: Getting away from danger and creating breathing room

What it may still need: Control over closeness and distance, and permission to set its own pace

Freeze part

Protects by staying alert, still and unseen.

How it may show up

- Fear, panic, anxiety, phobias
- Feeling paralyzed, unable to speak or act
- Startling easily, scanning for danger
- Fear of being seen, even when being praised

Its gift: Keeping you hidden and alert so you could avoid harm

What it may still need: Safety and reassurance, a sense that it can be seen without being hurt

Submit part

Protects by going along, giving in, and staying small.

How it may show up

- Shame, depression, hopelessness, feeling "less than"
- Difficulty saying no, people-pleasing, caretaking
- Low energy, collapse, passivity
- Beliefs like "it's my fault" or "I don't deserve good things"

Its gift: Surviving situations where resistance would have made things worse

What it may still need: To hear it is not to blame, that it is worthy, and that it no longer has to carry the burden

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

Attach / cry-for-help part

Protects by seeking closeness and rescue.

How it may show up

- Longing for someone to care, fear of abandonment
- Clinging, separation anxiety, idealizing others
- Feeling crushed by small disappointments
- Seeing only the warm smile and missing warning signs

Its gift: Keeping the hope of connection alive

What it may still need: Warmth, attention, and consistent presence that it can count on

REFLECTION

Which of these parts do you recognize most easily?

Which feel most uncomfortable to think about?

Which part do you tend to see as "the real me"? Which do you call "not me"?

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

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SECTION 5

Your Brain and Body

Why parts can feel so real, so fast, and so hard to talk yourself out of.

Two hemispheres. Fisher draws on split-brain research showing that the left and right sides of the brain work quite differently. The left side tends to be verbal, logical and task-focused, and stays practical under stress. The right side is more nonverbal, emotional and body-based, and holds experiences as images, sensations and feelings. Children are right-brain dominant for most of childhood, and the bridge between the hemispheres (the corpus callosum) matures slowly. This makes it easier for experiences to be held separately on each side. Research Fisher cites links abuse and neglect to a smaller corpus callosum.

In the Structural Dissociation model, the functioning self leans on the left brain and the trauma-related parts live mostly in right-brain, survival-oriented experience. This is a simplified model, but it helps explain why you can "know" you're safe and still feel terrified.

Implicit memory. Under extreme threat, the brain's alarm (the amygdala) fires, and the areas that put events in order and into words (the hippocampus and prefrontal cortex) go offline. Instead of a clear story, the experience is stored as raw pieces: body sensations, emotions, impulses, images and smells. Later, these pieces return as feelings in the present, without the label "this is a memory." A racing heart, sudden shame or an urge to run may be the past speaking.

Triggers. Reminders of the past can be obvious or very subtle, such as a tone of voice, a smell, a time of year, criticism, closeness, distance or even kindness. When a part is triggered, it reacts as though the old danger is happening now.

KEY IDEA

The window of tolerance

The window of tolerance is the range in which we can feel emotions and still think clearly. Above it is **hyperarousal** (the sympathetic system): panic, rage, racing thoughts. Below it is **hypoarousal** (the parasympathetic system): numbness, collapse, exhaustion, shutdown.

Fisher explains that children in ongoing danger rarely get the chance to develop a wide window. Their bodies learned to stay ready for action or to disconnect. Fight, flight, freeze and attach parts tend to be linked to high activation, and submit parts to low activation. Even calm can feel strange or

KEY IDEA (CONT.)

unsafe at first. That is normal, and it changes with practice.

KEY IDEA

Symptoms as messages

Fisher invites a shift in how we see symptoms. Anxiety, depression, rage, shame, stuckness, self-harm and fear of change can all be understood as communications from parts who still believe they are in danger. Instead of asking "What's wrong with me?" we can ask "Which part of me is reacting, and what is it afraid of?"

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SECTION 6

Self-Alienation

The hidden cost of surviving: turning against the parts of us who carried the pain.

To survive, many people learn to **own** some parts of themselves and **disown** others. A person may identify with the capable professional and despise the needy child inside. Another may identify with the hopeless, depressed part and believe the functioning self is a fraud. Some identify with an angry part, others with a caretaking or pleasing part.

Fisher calls this **self-alienation**. It once made sense, but over time it tends to bring:

- Growing self-loathing and harsh inner criticism
- Disconnection from feelings, or feeling flooded by them
- Addictive or self-destructive behavior
- Struggles between closeness and distance, vulnerability and control, shame and pride
- Feeling like a fraud, or as if you are always pretending

Fisher describes self-alienation as an *internal wall* that blocks two things healing requires: accepting that it really happened, and welcoming home the child who lived through it. She also observes that the inner relationship often recreates the old environment. If a child was ignored, the young parts are ignored again inside. If a child was criticized, a critical part repeats the criticism.

The alternative isn't forcing yourself to love every part right away. It is a slow shift toward **curiosity**, then **compassion**, then **welcome**. Many survivors who can't feel kindness toward themselves find they can feel it toward a frightened child. In this approach, that is enough. Compassion feels the same in the body whoever it's aimed at.

KEY IDEA

Selves-acceptance

Fisher plays on the word self-acceptance: healing is *selves*-acceptance, one part at a time. She suggests thinking of parts as roommates who share one body and one home. You can keep fighting every battle, or you can learn to live together.

REFLECTION

Which parts of yourself do you most want to get rid of?

What would it mean to treat those parts the way you were treated as a child? What would it mean to treat them differently?

Is there anyone, like a child, a friend or a pet, toward whom compassion comes easily? What does that feel like in your body?

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SECTION 7

Noticing Parts

The first skill is not changing anything. It is simply noticing, with interest.

Most of us assume every thought and feeling is "mine," a statement about who we are. Fisher asks clients to try a different assumption: **any distressing thought, feeling or body reaction may be a communication from a part.** This small shift creates a little space between you and the feeling. You can still feel it, but it is usually less intense, and you can become curious instead of overwhelmed.

Mindfulness is what makes this possible. Mindful noticing engages the prefrontal cortex and calms the brain's alarm system. It slows things down enough to observe instead of react.

Dual awareness means holding two things at once: one foot in the present, like your breath, your spine, your feet on the floor and the room around you, and one foot with the part's feelings from the past. From dual awareness you can feel a part's fear without being swallowed by it, and you can see that you're safe now even though the part doesn't believe it yet.

KEY IDEA

Signs that a part may be active

- Feelings that seem bigger than the situation
- The same thoughts or reactions repeating, especially old, familiar ones
- Strong body sensations: tightness, collapse, heat, numbness, shaking
- Harsh, hopeless or self-punishing beliefs
- Inner conflict, ambivalence or indecision, even about small things
- Procrastination or self-sabotage after progress
- Negative reactions to positive things, like praise, kindness or success
- Feeling or sounding much younger than your age

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

KEY IDEA

Identifying parts by their signature

Each part tends to have a recognizable "signature" in the body and emotions. Over time you can learn these, for example:

- **Clenched jaw, tight fists, heat, sharp words**: possibly a fight part
- **Restless legs, urge to leave, numbing out**: possibly a flight part
- **Held breath, stillness, wide eyes, panic**: possibly a freeze part
- **Slumped posture, heavy limbs, lowered gaze, shame**: possibly a submit part
- **Ache in the chest, longing, tearfulness, "please don't leave"**: possibly an attach part

Fisher also notes that each part sees the world through its own lens. A fight part scans for threat, an attach part sees only warmth, and a submit part notices evidence that you don't belong.

TRY THIS

Practice: the language of parts

When you notice a strong feeling, try changing the words:

- Instead of "I'm worthless," try "A part of me feels worthless."
- Instead of "I'm terrified," try "A young part of me is terrified."
- Instead of "I want to quit," try "Part of me wants to run, and part of me wants to stay."

Then ask: did the feeling get stronger, weaker or stay the same? Many people notice a slight easing.

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

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SECTION 8

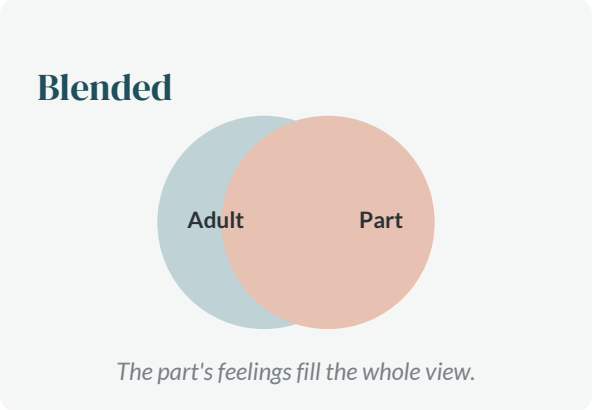
Blending and Unblending

When a part's feelings fill the whole screen, we lose sight of the present.

Blending (a term from Internal Family Systems) means becoming one with a part, so that its feelings, beliefs and impulses seem like yours and seem to be about right now. When blended with a frightened part, the world looks dangerous. When blended with an ashamed part, you look defective. When blended with a hopeless part, the future looks empty.

Fisher describes **"insta-blending"** as the automatic, lightning-fast habit of merging with whichever part feels strongest. It once helped you react quickly to danger. Now it keeps the trauma feeling alive, because you are seeing today through the eyes of a part who still lives back then.

FIGURE 2 BLENDED AND UNBLENDED



Unblending creates enough distance for connection, not separation.

Unblending means stepping back just enough to feel the part *and* be yourself. The goal isn't to push the part away or go numb. Some people swing from feeling everything to feeling nothing. Unblending aims for the middle: "I can feel her, and she can feel me."

TRY THIS

Five steps to unblending

Adapted from a structured sequence Fisher demonstrates in the book. Go slowly, and repeat often.

1 **Name it as a part.** Notice the feeling and put it in parts language, out loud or silently: "She's scared," "He's ashamed," "A part of me is upset."

2 **Feel your adult body.** Gently engage your core muscles so the part can sense your presence. Check: can you still feel the part?

3 **Lengthen your spine.** Sit or stand a little taller, making space between the vertebrae. Let the part notice how big and grown-up you are now.

4 **Bring in your wise adult.** Think of a role in which you are calm and capable, such as a parent, supervisor, teacher or friend. What would you say to someone in that role who felt the way this part feels? Say it to the part.

5 **Check in.** Ask the part if that helps, or if it needs something else. Thank it for letting you know how it feels.

TRY THIS

Other ways to unblend

- Orient to the room: name five things you can see right now.
- Notice your feet on the floor and the support under you.
- Say: "This feeling is a part's feeling memory. It isn't telling me about today."
- Draw, map or use small objects to show the parts. Seeing them outside you can create perspective.
- Remind the part: "I'm here. I'm grown up. We're in [today's place] now."

REFLECTION

Which part do you blend with most often? What usually triggers it?

What does it feel like in your body when you're blended? When you're unblended?

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

REFLECTION (CONT.)

Which unblending step was easiest for you? Which was hardest?

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

09

SECTION 9

The Wise, Compassionate Adult

Every part needs someone to lead, and that someone is already inside you.

Fisher combines two ideas. From Structural Dissociation comes the **going-on-with-normal-life self**, the part that can act, plan and make decisions for the whole system. From Internal Family Systems comes **Self**, the inner presence marked by qualities such as curiosity, compassion, calm, clarity, creativity, courage, confidence and connectedness. Together they describe a **wise, compassionate adult**, or "wise mind": a leader who stays in the present, can see all the parts from a wider view, and acts with kindness for the good of the whole.

Many survivors say "There's no adult in here." Fisher gently disagrees. Unless the brain has been injured, the capacities of the prefrontal cortex are still there, even if they've been hard to reach for years. She compares the brain to a vast library that doesn't lose what it has stored. If you have ever had a moment of curiosity, clarity or confidence, that ability is still in you.

TRY THIS

Finding your wise adult

- Think of roles you play, or once played, where you are capable: parent, coworker, coach, artist, volunteer, friend or pet owner.
- Notice what happens in your body when you remember those times: posture, breath, energy.
- Ask: what would I say to a child, student or friend who felt this way?
- Notice that the part of you that wants to heal, and that is reading this, is your normal life self.

KEY IDEA

Pick one quality

If compassion feels overwhelming, Fisher suggests choosing just one quality to practice. For one person compassion was too flooding and calm was triggering, so she started with simple **curiosity**:

KEY IDEA (CONT.)

observing her body's reactions as "things of interest." Start wherever is possible for you.

REFLECTION

When have you been at your wisest and kindest with someone else?

Which of the qualities (curiosity, calm, compassion, clarity, courage, confidence, creativity, connectedness) comes most easily to you?

What might your parts need from your wise adult this week?

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

10

SECTION 10

Welcoming Young Parts

Healing happens through relationship, and that includes the relationship inside you.

Fisher reclaims the old word "host" for the normal life self. In her view, it doesn't mean an empty container. It means a host who offers **hospitality**: the homeowner who provides shelter, food and welcome to every part. The normal life self runs the body and the household, so it is the natural home base for the whole system.

Why welcome parts that are turning life upside down? Fisher offers several reasons, in her caring but challenging way. Rejecting wounded children because they're inconvenient repeats the neglect you suffered. The parts helped you survive, and leaving them behind is a poor thank-you. As long as their distress is your distress, a calmer life depends on their feeling safe.

TRY THIS

Steps toward welcome

- **Notice** the part by its feeling or body signature.
- **Get a sense of its age.** Ask, "How old does this part feel?"
- **Ask how you feel toward it.** If the answer is irritation or fear, that's another part. Ask it to step back a little.
- **Acknowledge what it went through.** You don't need details. A felt sense of what the child endured is enough.
- **Offer something it needs:** your presence, reassurance, a gesture such as reaching out a hand or placing a hand on your heart.
- **Notice the response** in your body. Does anything soften, warm or settle? Stay with that moment for several breaths.
- **Thank the part**, and promise to come back.

Fisher stresses **repetition**. Young parts who were let down don't trust after one kind moment. They may want you there and still hold back. Trust grows from showing up day after day, communicating that

you care how they feel. Some clients set phone reminders to check in with a part, just as they would for a child's schedule.

She also warns against saying the right words without feeling them. Parts can tell. Slow down and notice what changes when the part senses you are really there.

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Phrases you might offer a young part

- "I see how scared you are. It makes sense, after what you went through."
- "That was then. I'm here now, and I'm grown up."
- "You don't have to handle this alone anymore."
- "You're not in trouble. You're not bad. You were a child."
- "Thank you for helping us survive."
- "I'm glad you're here. I want you to feel safe."

NOTES

11

SECTION 11

Common Inner Conflicts

Many struggles that look like indecision or resistance are parts pulling in opposite directions.

Fisher describes certain inner conflicts as predictable, because each survival defense tends to set off another:

INNER CONFLICT

Attach vs. fight and flight

When the attach part reaches for closeness, the fight part may sound the alarm ("Don't trust them") and the flight part may want to leave. The result can be a pattern of clinging, then pushing away; idealizing someone, then feeling betrayed; or endless agonizing over whether to stay or go. Fisher notes that these conflicts often surface in close relationships, including therapy.

Example in the spirit of the book: a friend offers a ride but has to hurry off afterward. The adult sees kindness. A young attach part feels hurt because it longed for unhurried attention, and the fight part decides the friend is "cold." Seeing both parts makes the reaction understandable.

INNER CONFLICT

Fight (critic) vs. submit (shame)

A fight part's harsh criticism, often felt as self-hatred, triggers the submit part's shame and hopelessness. The critic may echo the voice of a past caregiver. Underneath, it is often trying to prevent failure or prevent being hurt.

INNER CONFLICT

Normal life progress vs. frightened parts

Sometimes the steps forward set off the alarm: a promotion, praise, a new relationship, more visibility. To a freeze part, being seen can feel dangerous, and a fight part may expect to be used. Fisher points out that special attention sometimes came before abuse, so kindness itself can feel threatening.

TRY THIS

Working with conflicts

- Name both sides as parts: "Part of me wants this, and another part is scared of it."
- Get curious about each side's fear: what is it trying to prevent?
- Validate both. Each is trying to keep you safe.
- Let the wise adult decide, with care for both parts, rather than letting the strongest part take over.
- Thank the protective part and show it you have heard its warning.

Shame runs through many of these conflicts. Fisher reframes shame as a survival response linked to the submit part. Making yourself small and "less than" once reduced the danger. Seeing shame as a part's feeling memory, not the truth about you, is often the first step toward loosening it.

NOTES

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

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SECTION 12

Self-Harm and Suicidal Parts

Even the most frightening parts are trying, in their own way, to help you survive.

SAFETY

If you are in danger now

Please contact your therapist, call or text **988**, or go to the nearest emergency room. Understanding parts is not a substitute for crisis care.

Fisher's Trauma-Informed Stabilization Treatment (TIST) reframes self-harm, suicidal impulses, eating disorders and addiction as actions of parts, usually fight or flight parts, trying to bring relief. She doesn't see them as attention-seeking or manipulation. The sequence she describes is like a "perfect storm":

- A trigger stirs up an implicit memory.
- The body's alarm activates and the thinking brain goes offline, leaving the normal life self disempowered.
- A part acts on its survival instinct to bring relief, through cutting, purging, drinking, restricting or planning to die.
- For a short time there is relief or a sense of control, which reinforces the cycle.
- Afterward, exhaustion and collapse often follow.

Fisher explains that these behaviors work, briefly, on the nervous system. Self-harm and suicidal planning can bring a surge of power, calm and control, and endorphins can bring relief. Restricting, bingeing and purging can numb. Substances can numb or energize. Knowing this isn't permission. It explains why stopping takes more than willpower.

KEY IDEA

Which "I" feels suicidal?

Fisher asks us not to assume that "I feel suicidal" means the whole person wants to die. It may be one part, while the normal life self still wants to live. Helpful questions include:

- Which part feels this way right now? What triggered it?
- What is this part hoping to accomplish? How is it trying to protect me?
- What is it afraid would happen if it stopped?
- What would it need from me to trust that I can handle things?
- Where is my normal life self, and what could it do to help the young parts?

In one case in the book, a client learned that her suicidal fight part's purpose was to keep people from getting close enough to hurt her. Understanding that helped her begin building trust with it. Fisher describes such parts as wanting to die in order to live: the wish to die often began as a way to endure the unendurable.

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Helpful phrases

- "It's the fight part. I don't have to do what it says."
- "I hear you. You're trying to stop the pain. Let's find another way together."
- "The little one is hurting. I'm going to take care of her first."

NOTES

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SECTION 13

Earned Secure Attachment

The goal is not forgetting the past. It is feeling safe and welcome inside yourself now.

Researchers use the term **earned secure attachment** for adults whose early attachment was insecure or disorganized but who later reach the resilience associated with secure attachment. They can look back on childhood without being overwhelmed, and they can offer attuned care to others. Fisher points to research suggesting that its benefits are very similar to those of growing up securely attached. That is hopeful news: early wounds do not have to be permanent.

Fisher adds a new route to earning it: a loving, attuned relationship between your wise adult self and your young parts. The ingredients are the same as in any secure relationship: putting the other's needs first, welcome, attunement, warmth, and staying connected even when you're upset.

KEY IDEA

How repair happens inside

- A young part's distress is heard as a signal, the way a parent hears a baby's cry.
- The adult unblends and gets curious rather than avoiding or merging.
- The adult tries different ways to soothe until something lands.
- Success shows up in the body: a breath, slower heart rate, settling or relief.
- The adult stays with the part instead of moving on quickly, so the part feels held in mind.

These moments can bring what Fisher calls the **"grief of relief"**: tears that come when a part finally feels understood. By lingering in such moments, we help the brain encode a new feeling memory of safety and closeness, a "missing experience" the child never had.

Every part needs something different. Young parts may need holding and comfort. A fight part's missing experience is usually *respect*, for its strength and its need for boundaries and fairness. A flight part needs control over closeness and distance. Fisher writes that protective parts treated as heroes rather than villains often become loyal allies. Resolution means welcoming all the parts, not picking favorites.

Fisher describes **integration** as something that unfolds naturally as compassion and connection grow, not as a goal to force. Quoting Daniel Siegel, she describes it as differentiation with linkage: knowing your parts as distinct and connecting them in a caring whole.

"Welcome all the children, without favorites or scapegoats."

Paraphrasing the spirit of Fisher's closing chapter

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SECTION 14

Daily Practice

Small, repeated moments of noticing and welcome build trust over time.

TRY THIS

A five-minute daily check-in

- **Arrive (1 min).** Feel your feet and seat. Lengthen your spine. Take a few slow breaths. Name where you are and today's date.
- **Notice (1 min).** Scan your body and emotions. What's here? Tightness, heaviness, restlessness, worry?
- **Name (1 min).** Put it in parts language: "A part of me is..." Get a sense of which part it might be and how old it feels.
- **Offer (1 min).** From your wise adult, offer one thing: a kind sentence, a hand on your heart, a promise to take care of something.
- **Thank and close (1 min).** Notice any shift. Thank the part. Let it know when you'll check in again.

TRY THIS

The meditation circle

Fisher shares the idea of a daily meditation circle that one client came up with. Sit quietly and imagine inviting your parts to join you in a circle. No one has to talk, but anyone who has a worry can share it. Listen, take note, and let them know what you'll do with what they told you. You might bring it to therapy or make a change in your day.

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Everyday phrases

- "Which part of me is feeling this?"
- "This is a feeling memory, not a fact about today."
- "I can feel you, and I'm still here."
- "Part of me wants to, and part of me doesn't. Both make sense."
- "You don't have to protect me that way anymore. I've got this."
- "What do you need from me right now?"
- "Thank you for trying to keep us safe."

TRY THIS

When a trigger hits

- Pause. Name it: "I've been triggered."
- Orient: look around and name what's here and now.
- Unblend: "A part of me is reacting to the past."
- Soothe: offer the part reassurance from your adult self.
- Choose: decide what the wise adult will do next.

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

Journaling Prompts

REFLECTION

For the coming weeks

Draw or map your parts. Where do they live in your body? How do they relate to one another?

Write a letter from your wise adult to a young part. Then write the part's reply.

Describe a recent trigger. Which parts reacted, in what order?

What has your fight part protected you from? What might it need from you?

What does your normal life self want for your future?

When has a part surprised you by being helpful?

What "missing experience" might a young part need? How could you offer a little of it this week?

Finish the sentence: "If all my parts felt welcome, my life might look like..."

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

SAFETY

Grounding when it's too much

- Press your feet into the floor and notice the support under you.
- Name five things you see, four you hear, three you can touch.
- Hold something cold, or sip water slowly.
- Make your exhale longer than your inhale.
- Remind yourself of the date, your age and where you are.

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Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)

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SECTION 15

For Therapists

Key interventions and stance drawn from the book, for teaching and in-session use.

CLINICIAN NOTE: FOUNDATIONS

Stance and framing

- Start with psychoeducation on structural dissociation, the window of tolerance and implicit memory. Fisher sees making the model visible to clients as empowering and as a way to level the power differential.
- Shift from processing events to transforming the client's relationship to parts. Detailed narrative is not required; a felt sense of what younger selves endured is enough.
- Treat every symptom as a communication from a part. Reframe resistance, acting out or manipulation as survival responses.
- Understand stuckness and ruptures as internal conflicts between parts being played out in therapy, not just transference.

CLINICIAN NOTE: IN SESSION

Core interventions

- **Parts language, used persistently:** "Which 'I' feels ashamed?" "Notice the part that says it can't."
- **Assume distress belongs to a part,** and ask the client to check whether naming it as "her feeling" changes the intensity.
- **Mindful tracking** of thoughts, emotions, sensations and movement impulses without interpretation.
- **Name blending as you see it:** "It looks like you're blended with the anxious part today."
- **Teach an unblending protocol** with somatic resources: core, spine, orienting.

CLINICIAN NOTE: IN SESSION (CONT.)

- **Access the normal life self** through competent roles: "What would you tell your student or employee?"
- **"How do you feel toward that part?"** Use it to separate the adult's stance from other parts' reactions.
- **Externalize** the system with drawings, diagrams or objects (the book describes a client using small rubber ducks).
- **Deepen attunement:** invite a reaching gesture, then ask the part, "What's it like to feel someone care?" Linger on the body response.
- **Act as a broker of secure attachment,** narrating moment-to-moment connection between adult and part so it can be encoded.

HIGH-RISK BEHAVIOR

Safety (TIST)

- Ask which part is suicidal or self-destructive. Do not assume the whole person is.
- Separate a part's intention from its action: what is it trying to accomplish?
- Ask what the part fears would happen if it stopped, and what it would need in order to trust the adult.
- Frame every part, including suicidal parts, by its contribution to survival. Shaming or fighting these parts tends to polarize them.
- Teach the biology of how unsafe behaviors regulate the nervous system.
- Maintain standard risk assessment and safety planning alongside the parts work.

CLINICIAN NOTE: KEEP IN MIND

Cautions

- Pace carefully. Feeling too much blocks compassion just as feeling too little does.
- Watch for clients saying the right words without an embodied connection.
- Expect alliance swings driven by attach and fight parts. Ally with both sides.
- Help clients thank and respect harder-to-love parts, not only the vulnerable ones.
- Watch for signs of a dissociative disorder (time loss, switching, hearing voices) and assess formally. The book devotes a chapter to DID and OSDD/DDNOS.

Fisher integrates Structural Dissociation theory with Sensorimotor Psychotherapy, Internal Family Systems, mindfulness and clinical hypnosis. Consult the book and appropriate training for full protocols, including the appendices on unblending and the meditation circle.

CLINICIAN NOTE: CREDIT

Source

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, *Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors: Overcoming Internal Self-Alienation* (New York: Routledge, 2017). This guide summarizes and paraphrases the book's ideas in original language for educational use. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by the author or publisher, and it is not a substitute for therapy.

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SECTION 16

Glossary

Key terms in plain language.

Animal defenses. Automatic survival responses shared with other mammals: fight, flight, freeze, submit (feign death) and cry for help or attach.

Attach / cry-for-help part. A part driven by the instinct to seek closeness and rescue; often holds loneliness and fear of abandonment.

Blending. Merging with a part so its feelings and beliefs feel like yours and seem to be about the present.

Dual awareness. Holding present-moment awareness and a part's feelings at the same time.

Earned secure attachment. Security developed later in life despite insecure early attachment; associated with resilience.

Going-on-with-normal-life self. The present-oriented part that manages daily life, seeks safety and stability, and can lead the system.

Implicit memory. Memory held as feelings, sensations and impulses, without a sense of "remembering."

Insta-blending. A habit of automatically and instantly merging with the strongest part.

Integration. A natural outcome of differentiating parts and linking them with compassion; not something to force.

Missing experience. A healing experience a part never had, such as comfort, respect or safety, that can be offered now.

Self-alienation. Owning some parts and disowning or rejecting others, which keeps the inner world unsafe.

Structural dissociation. A model (Van der Hart, Nijenhuis & Steele) in which trauma divides the personality into a daily-life part and trauma-related survival parts.

Trigger. A present-day cue that activates implicit memories and survival responses.

TIST. Trauma-Informed Stabilization Treatment, Fisher's approach to stabilizing unsafe behavior through parts work.

Unblending. Stepping back from a part enough to feel it while remaining your adult self.

Window of tolerance. The range of arousal in which we can feel and still think; above it is hyperarousal, below it is hypoarousal.

Wise compassionate adult. The normal life self drawing on qualities like curiosity, calm and compassion to lead and care for parts.

Based on concepts from Janina Fisher, Healing the Fragmented Selves of Trauma Survivors (2017)